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Chapter 2 - USCIS-Issued Secure Identity Documents

Guidance

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A. Personal Information Used on Secure Identity Documents

USCIS issues a variety of secure identity documents that establish identity and immigration status in the United States. Personal information included on USCIS-issued secure identity documents includes, but is not limited to, a benefit requestor's biometrics, full legal name, date and country of birth, sex, and A-number.

1. Biometrics

USCIS has general authority to require and collect biometrics from any applicant, petitioner, sponsor, derivative, dependent, beneficiary, or requestor filing for any immigration, citizenship, and naturalization benefit.^[1]

If the benefit request filed requires biometrics, and the requestor is in the United States, USCIS schedules a biometric services appointment at a local Application Support Center (ASC).^[2] If the benefit requestor is outside of the United States, biometrics are captured by a USCIS international office, a U.S. embassy or consulate, or a U.S. military facility. The biometrics collected from the benefit requestor allow USCIS to verify identity and conduct national security and criminal history background checks. USCIS also uses the benefit requestor's biometric information for the initial issuance or replacement of a secure identity document.

2. Full Legal Name

All USCIS-issued secure identity documents contain the benefit requestor's full legal name.^[3] Documents USCIS issues do not include nicknames. They do not contain initials, unless an initial appears on the official birth certificate, or the requestors legally changed their name to include an initial.

USCIS does not suspend the adjudication of a benefit request pending a court determination of a name change or other efforts by the requestor to establish a new legal name. USCIS creates secure identity documents using the legal name in place when the benefit request is decided. If the applicant's name changes after filing, USCIS only issues the resulting identity document, if any, in the new name if the applicant provides supporting documentation of the name change before USCIS makes a decision on the benefit.^[4]

Name Changes

If requestors change their name after USCIS issues the secure identity document, the requestor may file an application, with the appropriate fee,^[5] to request USCIS re-issue the secure identity document with the new name.^[6] The requestor must provide sufficient evidence of the name change. USCIS does not have legal authority to change a person's name. Requestors who changed their name must submit evidence that they completed any name change procedure according to the relevant U.S. state or foreign law.^[7] The name change may or may not be recorded on the birth certificate, marriage certificate, or other vital document record.^[8]

3. Date of Birth

In general, the official date of birth is the date recorded on the requestor's birth certificate. USCIS recognizes dates of birth based on the Gregorian calendar in the following order: month, day, and year. Some foreign countries issue documents with the date of birth in a different order.^[9] Most translations should have the date in the order of the month, day, and year. However, officers should verify the order of a translated date before issuing documents to avoid discrepancies.

If there is a discrepancy between a translated birth certificate and other government-issued documentation, the requestor must provide compelling evidence that the date of birth on the birth certificate is incorrect or miscalculated. For naturalization certificates, USCIS cannot change a recorded date of birth, except to correct a USCIS clerical error.^[10]

4. Sex

USCIS issues certain documents indicating the benefit requestor's sex.^[11] USCIS does not leave the benefit requestor's sex blank on such documents.

B. Delivery of Secure Identity Documents

USCIS mails secure identity documents through the [U.S. Postal Service](https://www.usps.gov) (USPS) to the address provided on a benefit request, unless the requestor requested that USCIS send any secure identity document to the U.S.

business address of the attorney of record or accredited representative.^[12]

In general, USCIS only sends secure identity documents to U.S. addresses. The requestor may, however, request that any secure identity document be sent to a designated military or diplomatic address for pickup in a foreign country, if permitted.^[13] For example, certain travel documents (such as reentry permits and refugee travel documents) may be sent to a U.S. embassy or consulate or USCIS international office for the requestor to pick up, if this request is made when the requestor files the benefit application.^[14]

C. Tracking Delivery

Benefit requestors may track the delivery status of their secure identity document by signing up for a [Case Status Online](#) account to obtain a tracking number. With a tracking number, requestors may also register for [Informed Delivery](#) through USPS to get previews of mail in transit.^[15]

D. Making Address Changes

Aliens must report any change of address within 10 days of moving within the United States or its territories.^[16] If a mailing address changes after a benefit request is filed, the requestor should update it online with USCIS and USPS as soon as possible to ensure he or she receives any secure identity documents USCIS sends in the mail. If more than one application or petition is pending, the requestor should ensure that USCIS updates the address on all pending benefit requests.

Requestors should use the [USPS Look Up a Zip Code](#) tool to ensure they are providing a complete address using the standard abbreviations and formatting recognized by USPS.

Footnotes

^[^ 1] See [8 CFR 103.2\(b\)\(9\)](#). See [8 CFR 103.16](#).

^[^ 2] For more information, see [Preparing for Your Biometric Services Appointment](#).

^[^ 3] See [8 CFR 320.3\(b\)\(1\)\(viii\)-\(ix\)](#), [8 CFR 322.3\(b\)\(1\)\(xiii\)](#) and [8 CFR 338.1\(b\)](#). See [6 CFR 37.3](#) for the full legal name description in the REAL ID Act, [Pub. L. 109-13 \(PDF\)](#) (May 11, 2005). USCIS uses the name provided in the benefit request, or otherwise submitted in connection with the request while the request is pending, so long as USCIS can verify the name. For more information on what USCIS considers a legal name for purposes of verifying identifying information as part of the adjudication of the benefit request, see Volume 1, General Policies and Procedures, Part E, Adjudications, Chapter 5, Verification of Identifying Information, Section A, Full Legal Name [\[1 USCIS-PM E.1\(A\)\]](#). Certain USCIS electronic systems have character limitations which could result in a shortened name (if the name is too long) or a name without hyphens on USCIS-produced secure documents.

^[^ 4] For more information, see the [Updating or Correcting Your Documents](#) webpage.

[^5] See Fee Schedule ([Form G-1055](#)).

[^6] See Chapter 3, Reissuance of Secure Identity Documents [[11 USCIS-PM A.3](#)].

[^7] There may be instances in which evidence of a name change is unobtainable because of country conditions or personal circumstances. In some situations, USCIS permits such requestors to submit secondary evidence or affidavits to establish their identity. Any affidavit should explain the reasons primary evidence is unavailable. For more information on identity documents that cannot be obtained in particular countries and during specific time periods, see the U.S. Department of State's [U.S. Visa: Reciprocity and Civil Documents by Country](#) webpage. Requestors of certain humanitarian benefits may be able to establish with testimony alone that they completed any name change procedure according to relevant law.

[^8] See Volume 1, General Policies and Procedures, Part E, Adjudications, Chapter 5, Verification of Identifying Information, Section A, Full Legal Name [[1 USCIS-PM E.5\(A\)](#)].

[^9] Most western countries follow the Gregorian calendar. Other countries follow different calendars including the Hebrew (lunisolar calendar); Islamic (lunar calendar); and Julian (solar calendar). The calendars differ on days, months, and years.

[^10] See [8 CFR 338.5](#). USCIS may, however, change the date of birth on a certificate of citizenship for a person who has a U.S. court order or similar state vital record changing the date of birth. See Volume 12, Citizenship & Naturalization, Part K, Certificates of Citizenship and Naturalization, Chapter 4, Application for Replacement of Naturalization/Citizenship Document [[12 USCIS-PM K.4](#)].

[^11] For more information, see Volume 1, General Policies and Procedures, Part E, Adjudications, Chapter 5, Verification of Identifying Information, Section B, Personal Information, Subsection 2, Sex [[1 USCIS-PM E.5\(B\)\(2\)](#)].

[^12] See [8 CFR 103.2\(b\)\(19\)\(iii\)](#). A benefit requestor may also request to change, through written notice to USCIS, that USCIS mail the secure identity document to him or her instead of the attorney of record or legal representative.

[^13] For more information regarding mailing secure identity documents overseas, see [Travel Documents](#) and [Emergency Travel](#).

[^14] In general, if a requestor applies for advance parole while in the United States, and departs the United States before the advance parole document is issued, the requestor may be found inadmissible to the United States upon return, or even if admitted, may be found to have abandoned his or her application. There is no process for a requestor outside the United States traveling on a valid advance parole document or combo card (a card that combines an employment authorization document (EAD) and advance parole document) to apply for a replacement of a lost or stolen advance parole document to enable him or her to return the United States. In these cases, the requestor should contact the closest [USCIS international office](#) or U.S. embassy or consulate.

[^ 15] For more information on how to track the delivery of secure identity documents, see [How to Track Delivery of Your Notice or Secure Identity Document \(or Card\)](#).

[^ 16] See [INA 265](#). See [How to Change Your Address](#).

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